

Business Website Strategy Guide

A strategy guide for small businesses building or rebuilding a website — goals, audience, content strategy, CMS selection, and SEO foundations.

1. Website Strategy Framework

The most common reason a business website underperforms isn't bad design — it's the absence of a clear primary job for the site to do. A site trying to be everything to everyone usually does nothing especially well.

Define the Site's Primary Job

Business Goal	The Site's Job	Success Metric
Generate leads for a service business	Convince a visitor to request a quote or consultation	Number of qualified inquiries per month
Sell products directly	Move a visitor from browsing to checkout	Conversion rate, average order value
Establish credibility for a referral-based business	Confirm what a referred prospect already suspects before they call	Time on site, contact form completions from referred visitors
Reduce repetitive support questions	Answer common questions before someone has to ask	Reduction in support inquiries on covered topics

Pick one primary job. Secondary goals can still matter, but design and content priority decisions should be made in service of the primary job first.

Common Pitfall

- Designing the homepage around what the business wants to say about itself, rather than what the visitor needs to do next
- Treating every page as equally important, so the pages that actually drive the primary goal get the same shallow treatment as everything else

2. Audience Definition Tools

A useful audience definition doesn't need elaborate persona names and stock photos — it needs to answer what this visitor actually needs to know and what's stopping them from acting.

Audience Worksheet

Audience Segment	Primary Need	Key Objection	Ideal Action on Site
Example: Referred prospect researching before calling	Confirm the business is legitimate and does this specific work	"Is this actually a real, established business?"	View recent work examples, then call or submit a contact form

Questions to Answer for Each Segment

- What do they already know when they arrive, and what do they still need to learn?
- What's the single objection most likely to stop them from taking the next step?
- What device and context are they likely using (mobile while multitasking vs. desktop while comparing options carefully)?
- What's the one action that actually matters for this segment — not every possible action the site offers?

3. Content Strategy Guide

Most small business sites need a fairly consistent core set of pages — the strategic decision is less about which pages to include and more about which ones to invest real effort in first.

Page Priority

Page	Purpose	Priority
Homepage	Confirm the visitor is in the right place and direct them to their next step	Must-have
Services / Products	Answer “do you do what I need?” specifically, not generically	Must-have
Contact	Remove friction from taking the next step	Must-have
About	Build trust and answer “who am I actually dealing with?”	Should-have
Testimonials / Case Studies	Reduce the credibility objection with third-party proof	Should-have, higher priority if trust is the primary objection
FAQ	Deflect common questions before they become a support burden	Should-have if support volume is a real cost
Blog / Resources	Support ongoing SEO and nurture visitors not ready to act yet	Nice-to-have unless content marketing is a stated goal

Build and refine the “Must-have” pages thoroughly before spending significant effort on “Nice-to-have” pages, even if the nice-to-have page feels more interesting to write.

4. CMS Selection Matrix

This is a quick decision framework, not a full comparison — see the companion CMS Selection Comparison Matrix resource for a complete 20-criterion breakdown across all platforms.

Answer These First

- Do you have ongoing access to developer help, or will you be managing the site yourself?
- Is design flexibility important, or is a polished template good enough?
- Will content volume be high (frequent blog posts, large product catalog), or fairly static?
- Do you need the same content delivered to more than one channel (web, app, etc.), or just a website?

If you answered...	Consider
No dev help, template design is fine, low content volume	Wix or Squarespace
No dev help, but design flexibility matters	Webflow
Some dev help available, high content volume, want maximum long-term flexibility	WordPress
Dev team available, need multi-channel delivery	Headless CMS

5. SEO Foundation Checklist

These are the fundamentals that matter before any advanced SEO work is worth doing — advanced tactics on a foundation with gaps like these tend to underperform.

Item	Why It Matters
Every page has a unique title tag and meta description	Duplicate or missing titles confuse both search engines and visitors scanning results
Each key page targets one clear primary topic/keyword	Pages trying to rank for everything tend to rank well for nothing
Google Business Profile claimed and fully completed	Critical for local search visibility — often matters more than on-page SEO for local businesses
Business name, address, and phone number consistent across the site and all directory listings	Inconsistent NAP details undermine local search trust signals
Site is mobile-friendly	The majority of search traffic for most small businesses is mobile
Site uses HTTPS (SSL)	A baseline trust and ranking signal; most modern hosting includes this by default
An XML sitemap exists and is submitted to Google Search Console	Helps search engines discover and index pages efficiently
Core pages load reasonably quickly	Slow pages hurt both rankings and conversion — see the companion Website Performance Checklist for a full technical audit